

Hyperlinks

The internet wouldn't have much functionality if you could only look at one web page at a time. To ease the ability of users to move about your website and to visit related pages of interest we need to add hyperlinks to our html documents. This is done with the hyperlink tag.

Oddly the hyperlink tag is denoted with the letter a. The letter a is used because it means *anchor text*. Hence the `<a>` tag defines a hyperlink which will open a new web page when the user clicks on it. As you probably know hyperlinks are displayed to the user as underlined text, with blue color for a page they have not opened before and purple for web pages they've already visited.

Several attributes can be specified with the hyperlink tag. The most important is the *href* attribute which tells the browser which link to open when the user clicks on the text. So href is just the url of the target web page.

HTML 5 introduces some new attributes. For example, you can use download to tell the browser to begin downloading a file when the user clicks on the link.

The target specified in the href attribute can be a local file (relative to the web page) or any URL. The syntax you will use is:

```
<a href="url to open">Text displayed to user</a>
```

The text displayed to the user can be anything, most web page developers put descriptive text that makes it more readable and more amenable to search engines. But you can just put the URL there if desired. These days people automatically know that underlined blue text is a hyperlink so putting descriptive text is preferred.

Here is an example that will display a link to the New York Times website:

```
<body>
```

```
Hello World!
```

```
<br>
```

```
<a href="http://nytimes.com">New York Times</a>
```

```
<br>
```

This looks like so:

Hello World!

[New York Times](http://nytimes.com)

If we wanted to just display the actual link to the user, we could write:

```
<body>
```

Hello World!

```
<br>
```

```
<a href="http://nytimes.com">http://nytimes.com</a>
```

```
<br>
```

Then we would get:

Hello World!

<http://nytimes.com>

Now suppose you want to open a file on your own server. Consider the case of a web page named about.html in your same directory. Then you would write:

```
<body>
```

Hello World!

```
<br>
```

```
<a href="about.html">About Us</a>
```

```
<br>
```

If the file was in a folder called "Info" you'd write:

```
<body>
```

Hello World!

/Info/About Us

Often links are placed in the middle of a text string, for example:

Here is some more text linking to cable news network find out what the latest news is.

This displays as:

Here is some more text linking to [cable news network](http://cnn.com) find out what the latest news is.